CHAPTER 11

FROM MY COLD, DEAD HANDS: THE CHALLENGE OF LEAVING LEADERSHIP

Summary

This chapter discusses a key moment where leaders need support: when they are transitioning out of their leader roles, whether for retirement, organizational restructuring, or layoffs. It uses three interrelated perspectives to explain why leader role exits are so challenging: leadership is linked to identity and to a self-reinforcing social network, and fosters power addiction. It introduces a series of five Write-Reflect-Act exercises to spur individual thinking and/or group discussion, which individuals in formal or informal leadership roles can apply to understand why this role exit is relevant to them and their experiences.

Chapter Outline

Introduction

Leader Role and Identity

Why Leaving Leadership Is So Difficult: Three Perspectives

- Leadership as an Absorbing, Socially Constructed Role
  - Leader as Role: Identity Hierarchies
  - Social Construction: Social Validation and Transference
  - The Key Challenge for Leader Role Exits: Path Dependence and Self-Poverty
- Leadership as Social Network: Homophily, Hierarchy, and Centrality
  - Network Homophily
  - Network Hierarchy and Centrality
  - The Key Challenge for Leader Role Exits: The Loss of Social Ties (and Relevance)
- Leadership as Engendering Power Habituation and Reinforcement

Defining Addiction

Biological Processes in Addiction: The Case of Dopamine

Psychosocial Processes in Addiction: The Case of Narcissism

The Key Challenge for Leader Role Exits: Addiction Withdrawal

Conclusion

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Understand the relationship between leader role and leader identity.

2. Be able to explain three different viewpoints on why leaving positions of leadership is challenging.

3. Be able to identify situations where leaders will be more likely to struggle with exiting their role.

4. Be able to complete two Write-Reflect-Act exercises to evaluate your own situation and anticipate what exiting a leader role might feel like for you.

Case Questions

The chapter uses the running example of Alice, a retiring CFO of a large company, to provide insights about why the transition out of leadership might be challenging, especially for people who have come to identify themselves by their work. Alice has invested much time and effort in developing her in leader role and identity and risks losing these investments with the transition (leadership as identity); she is likely surrounded with people who are “like her” professionally who reinforce her position and status, and role exit means moving to a new social network (leadership as social network); and because leadership brings power—and, with this, “feel good” biological and psychosocial messages, giving up leadership may lead to

Alice experiencing feelings of withdrawal (leadership as fostering power addiction).

Instructors can guide students through the following questions:

1. If you were in Alice's position, exiting a leadership role, what steps would you take to transition? Would these steps happen before or after your transition? What would you expect

2. Time and choice are implicit in this chapter, and in the case of Alice. Leaders might or might not have time to plan their exit; they might be able to choose how and when they exit. How might time and choice affect the experience of role exit?

3. Based on your own observations of leaders exiting their roles, which of the three perspectives was most obvious to you? Which was most surprising?

Personal Development Activities

Instruct students to use the Write-Reflect-Act exercises to structure their own experiences and their observations of other leaders. Although the Act segment of many of these exercises is intentionally broader-scale for life planning, all five Write-Reflect-Act exercises can be used in-class or as take-home assignments with follow-up class discussion. In both cases, this would consist in allocating time for Writing and Reflecting (approximately 20-30 minutes for both) and discussion. This may be followed by time to create an Action plan on how to create specific steps that will allow the student to apply the suggested action to their own life.

Key Reading

Sonnenfeld, J. (1988). *The hero's farewell: What happens when CEOs retire.* Oxford University Press.

Further Reading

Kets de Vries, M. F. R. (1991). Whatever happened to the philosopher-king? The leader's addiction to power. *Journal of Management Studies*, 28(4), 339–351.

Newman, K. S. (1999). *Falling from grace: Downward mobility in the age of affluence.* University of California Press.

Nieberle, K. W., Acton, B. P., Braun, S., Lord, R. G., & Fu, Y. (2024). Leader identity on the fly: Intra-personal leader identity dynamics in response to strong events. *Journal of Business and Psychology*, *39*, 755–778. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10869-023-09906-7

Wittman, S. (2019). Lingering identities. *Academy of Management Review*, 44(4), 724–745.

Other Recommended Sources

Carmichael, S. G. (Host). (2018, November 20). How your identity changes when you change jobs (No. 657) [Audio podcast episode]. In *HBR IdeaCast*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/podcast/2018/11/how-your-identity-changes-when-you-change-jobs

Carmichael, S. G. (Host). (2017, August 31). Why everyone should see themselves as a leader (No. 592) [Audio podcast episode]. In *HBR IdeaCast*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/podcast/2017/08/why-everyone-should-see-themselves-as-a-leader